

Hegemonic Peace, Middle Power Conflicts, and the Politics of Legitimacy in Early East Asia

Abstract

Why do some hierarchical international systems exhibit peace between hegemons and subordinate states while experiencing frequent warfare among the subordinates themselves? This paper introduces a legitimacy-based theoretical framework to address this paradox, emphasizing the strategic pursuit of legitimacy as a fundamental driver of state behavior. We argue that while both hegemonic and middle-power leaders prioritize domestic legitimacy, the sources of that legitimacy differ. Hegemonic leaders are primarily concerned with demonstrating moral legitimacy, whereas middle-power leaders have a stronger need for performance legitimacy, which is rooted in their perceived competence. International legitimacy and recognition can serve as credible signals to convey these qualities—morality for hegemonic leaders and competence for middle-power leaders. As a result, hegemonic leaders refrain from expanding into middle powers in order to earn their recognition, while middle-power leaders actively seek recognition from the hegemon and pursue military achievements against their peers to bolster their domestic authority. We find empirical support for this dynamic in the interactions among states within the hierarchical system of early East Asia (345–700 CE), which included China as the hegemon and Goguryeo, Baekje, Silla, and Yamato Japan as major middle powers. Our study provides a theoretical framework for understanding how the pursuit of international legitimacy and, ultimately, domestic legitimacy drives both cooperation and conflict within hierarchical orders.

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Introduction

Why do some hierarchical international systems exhibit a paradoxical pattern of peace between the hegemon and subordinate states while experiencing frequent warfare among the subordinates themselves? Early East Asia between 345 and 700 CE presents us with a striking illustration of this: while the Chinese hegemon maintained remarkably peaceful relations with middle powers like Goguryeo, Baekje, Silla, and Yamato Japan, these same middle powers engaged in persistent and often intense conflicts with one another. This dualistic regional order, characterized by hegemonic restraint coupled with middle-power belligerence, challenges conventional theories of both hierarchical stability and interstate conflict.

This paradox becomes even more puzzling when we consider the material capabilities at play. The Chinese dynasties possessed overwhelming military and economic superiority that could have enabled territorial expansion, yet they generally refrained from conquering their neighbors. Meanwhile, the middle powers, despite their relative weakness and shared participation in the Chinese-led tributary system, directed their military ambitions not upward against the hegemon but laterally against each other.

What explains this distinctive pattern of selective peace and targeted conflict within a

single hierarchical order?

We argue that this dualistic pattern emerges from leaders' strategic pursuit of *domestic* legitimacy, which takes fundamentally different forms for hegemonic versus middle-power rulers. Our theory introduces a crucial distinction: while both types of leaders seek to enhance their domestic authority through international recognition, the sources of that legitimacy differ systematically. Leaders of hegemonic powers prioritize moral legitimacy: the need to be recognized as virtuous exemplars who uphold the normative foundations of the international order. In contrast, leaders of middle powers emphasize performance legitimacy: the imperative to demonstrate competence in ensuring state survival and security.

These divergent legitimacy imperatives generate distinct behavioral strategies at the international level. Hegemonic leaders pursue moral legitimacy by exercising strategic restraint, as international recognition by willing subordinates serves as a more credible signal of virtuous leadership than coerced submission. Territorial expansion would undermine this moral authority by eliminating the very states whose voluntary deference validates the hegemon's legitimacy. For middle-power leaders, however, performance legitimacy requires tangible demonstrations of capability. They

pursue a dual strategy: seeking recognition from the hegemon to signal external validation while launching military campaigns against peer competitors to showcase their effectiveness in securing resources and defending state interests. In sum, international legitimacy can be used to strengthen domestic legitimacy for both the hegemon and middle powers.

In contrast to traditional realist or geopolitical explanations, which emphasize balance-of-power dynamics, security-driven territorial expansion, and strategies such as spheres of influence or geopolitical buffers viewed as purely material pursuits, our legitimacy-based explanation reveals how these same geopolitical dynamics are themselves linked to domestic legitimacy concerns, fundamentally altering interstate behavior within hierarchical systems. Our analysis of early East Asia during the period 345-700 CE provides systematic evidence for this legitimacy-based explanation. Drawing on primary historical sources from China, Korea, and Japan, we construct a comprehensive dataset of 151 interstate conflicts. The quantitative evidence reveals a stark pattern: Chinese dynasties initiated only 18 wars during this period, primarily in response to direct challenges to their authority, while middle powers launched 133 conflicts, overwhelmingly targeting each other rather than the hegemon. Qualitative evidence from diplomatic records and succession crises further

demonstrates how legitimacy concerns shaped strategic choices, from Chinese emperors cultivating tributary relationships to Yamato rulers seeking Chinese titles while simultaneously invading Korean kingdoms.

This legitimacy-based framework makes several contributions to international relations theory. First, it advances the literature on international hierarchy by demonstrating how domestic legitimacy concerns fundamentally shape interstate behavior within hierarchical systems. While existing scholarship has explored how legitimacy matters for hierarchical stability, our theory specifies the microfoundations linking leaders' domestic survival needs to their international strategies.¹ Second, we contribute to the growing literature on middle powers by explaining their seemingly contradictory behavior (deference to the hegemon combined with aggression toward peers) as a coherent response to pressures for performance legitimacy. This helps bridge the gap between functional approaches emphasizing middle-power diplomacy,²

¹ David A. Lake, *Hierarchy in International Relations* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 2009); David C. Kang, *East Asia Before the West: Five Centuries of Trade and Tribute* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2010); Ji-Young Lee, "Hegemonic Authority and Domestic Legitimation: Japan and Korea under Chinese Hegemonic Order in Early Modern East Asia," *Security Studies* 25, no. 2 (April 2, 2016): 320–52, doi:10.1080/09636412.2016.1171970; Ayşe Zarakol, ed., *Hierarchies in World Politics* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2017).

² Andrew Fenton Cooper, Richard A. Higgott, and Kim Richard Nossal, *Relocating Middle Powers: Australia and Canada in a Changing World Order*, *Canada and International Relations* 6 (Vancouver: UBC Press, 1993); Bruce Gilley and Andrew O'Neil, eds., *Middle Powers and the Rise of*

and recent work on status competition.³ Third, our framework illuminates the relationship between hierarchy and regional conflict, showing how legitimacy-seeking can simultaneously stabilize vertical relations while destabilizing horizontal ones.

The article proceeds as follows. In the next section, we develop a legitimacy-based theory of dualistic regional order, distinguishing between moral and performance legitimacy and explaining how these shape hegemonic restraint and middle-power competition. Then, we present quantitative evidence on conflict patterns in early East Asia, demonstrating the rarity of hegemonic wars and the frequency of middle-power conflicts. Next, we provide qualitative evidence on the mechanisms linking legitimacy concerns to strategic behavior, examining both Chinese imperial restraint and Japanese expansionism. The conclusion summarizes our theoretical arguments and empirical findings, then explores their broader implications for understanding hierarchical orders, middle power behavior, and the complex relationship between legitimacy and conflict in international systems. We also identify promising directions for future research.

China (Washington, DC: Georgetown University Press, 2014).

³ Sarah Teo, "Toward a Differentiation-Based Framework for Middle Power Behavior," *International Theory* 14, no. 1 (March 2022): 1–24, doi:10.1017/S1752971920000688.

A Legitimacy-Based Theory of Dualistic Regional Order

The paradoxical coexistence of hegemonic peace and frequent middle-power conflicts in early East Asia requires a theoretical framework that can explain both patterns simultaneously. We develop a legitimacy-based theory to explain this dualistic feature of regional order, highlighting how the strategic pursuit of legitimacy shapes the behaviors of both the hegemon and middle powers. Specifically, within our model framework, the leaders of both hegemons and middle powers have incentives to use international legitimacy and recognition as a credible signal to enhance their domestic legitimacy in the eyes of their domestic audiences. However, the sources of domestic legitimacy differ between hegemons and middle powers: leaders of hegemons prioritize moral legitimacy, while leaders of middle powers focus on demonstrating performance legitimacy. As a result, the two employ different types of international legitimacy and recognition as credible signals to achieve their respective domestic objectives.

A Typology of Legitimacy

The concept of legitimacy has garnered widespread attention from social scientists since the pioneering work of Max Weber.⁴ At its core, legitimacy refers to the recognized and accepted rightfulness of authority, grounded not merely in coercion or material power but in adherence to shared norms, cultural values, and the effective provision of public goods.⁵ Subfields within political science, such as international relations and comparative politics, have each developed extensive bodies of literature on the definition, determinants, and consequences of legitimacy. However, they differ in their focus, particularly regarding the audiences responsible for evaluating and granting legitimacy.

The study of legitimacy within international relations centers on the international recognition that a state or an international organization receives from other members of the international system. This literature on why and how a state's international legitimacy matters in world politics is extensive and continues to grow.⁶ In this line

⁴ Martin E. Spencer, "Weber on Legitimate Norms and Authority," *The British Journal of Sociology* 21, no. 2 (1970): 123–34, doi:10.2307/588403.

⁵ Tom R. Tyler, "Psychological Perspectives on Legitimacy and Legitimation," *Annual Review of Psychology* 57 (2006): 375–400, doi:10.1146/annurev.psych.57.102904.190038.

⁶ Jennifer Gronau and Henning Schmidtke, "The Quest for Legitimacy in World Politics—

of research, legitimacy is often understood as the acceptance of a state's authority by the international audience, particularly by other states. Specifically, scholars increasingly emphasize legitimacy as a crucial factor in hierarchical international systems, wherein dominant states secure compliance not merely through coercion but also by establishing authority through shared norms, symbolic capital, and mutually recognized status.⁷ For example, David Kang highlights how China historically leveraged Confucian norms and cultural authority within the East Asian tribute system to legitimize its hierarchical dominance.⁸ Similarly, Ji-Young Lee demonstrates how recognition by a hegemon translates directly into enhanced authority for rulers of

International Institutions' Legitimation Strategies," *Review of International Studies* 42, no. 3 (July 2016): 535–57, doi:10.1017/S0260210515000492; Ian Hurd, "Legitimacy and Authority in International Politics," *International Organization* 53, no. 2 (April 1999): 379–408, doi:10.1162/002081899550913; Ian Hurd, "Legitimacy and Contestation in Global Governance: Revisiting the Folk Theory of International

Institutions," *The Review of International Organizations* 14, no. 4 (December 1, 2019): 717–29, doi:10.1007/s11558-018-9338-z; Jonas Tallberg and Michael Zürn, "The Legitimacy and Legitimation of International Organizations: Introduction and Framework," *The Review of International Organizations* 14, no. 4 (December 2019): 581–606, doi:10.1007/s11558-018-9330-7.

⁷ Lake, *Hierarchy in International Relations*; Paul Musgrave and Daniel H. Nexon, "Defending Hierarchy from the Moon to the Indian Ocean: Symbolic Capital and Political Dominance in Early Modern China and the Cold War," *International Organization* 72, no. 3 (July 2018): 591–626, doi:10.1017/S0020818318000139.

⁸ David C. Kang, "Hierarchy and Legitimacy in International Systems: The Tribute System in Early Modern East Asia," *Security Studies* 19, no. 4 (2010): 591–622; David C. Kang, "Authority and Legitimacy in International Relations: Evidence from Korean and Japanese Relations in Pre-Modern East Asia," *The Chinese Journal of International Politics* 5, no. 1 (March 1, 2012): 55–71, doi:10.1093/cjip/pos002.

subordinate states, thus stabilizing the hierarchical order in a mutually reinforcing process.⁹ In summary, this line of research focuses on the role of international legitimacy and recognition in shaping a state's identity and influencing its behavior.

The study of legitimacy in domestic politics, on the other hand, focuses on a leader or regime's perceived authority within the domestic sphere, which is crucial for their survival and governance. Domestic legitimacy plays a vital role in consolidating rule by reducing reliance on coercion and fostering voluntary compliance among the domestic audiences. This is especially important for newly installed leaders, who often face heightened challenges from domestic opposition.¹⁰ In essence, this body of literature highlights the importance of domestic legitimacy in securing a regime's or a leader's political survival by shaping the interactions between rulers and their domestic constituencies.

It is important to note that in both the international relations and the comparative politics literature, legitimacy is a multifaceted concept that can be assessed across different dimensions. Broadly, legitimacy derives from two primary sources: morality

⁹ Lee, "Hegemonic Authority and Domestic Legitimation," 320–52.

¹⁰ Austin Strange, "Legitimacy and Hegemony in Late Imperial China," *Security Studies*, September 14, 2024, <https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/abs/10.1080/09636412.2024.2382292>.

and performance.¹¹ Moral-based legitimacy, or normative legitimacy, emphasizes the moral and normative justification of authority, focusing on whether actions align with societal values, principles of justice, and fairness. This dimension is grounded in the idea that people are more likely to perceive authority as legitimate when it upholds moral standards. In contrast, performance-based legitimacy, or consequentialist legitimacy, highlights the practical outcomes and effectiveness of authority in delivering tangible benefits, such as security and welfare. In this case, legitimacy stems from an authority's ability to meet the needs and expectations of the people, regardless of its moral foundations. While moral legitimacy relies on adherence to ideals and principles, performance legitimacy is contingent on pragmatic success and welfare outcomes. Both dimensions play a critical role in shaping how authority is perceived and accepted by society.

While legitimacy—whether international or domestic—can be achieved by upholding normative principles or delivering excellent performance, its pursuit is inherently a calculated strategic choice. Even in the case of normative legitimacy, actors often seek it not because they genuinely internalize certain moral values, but because it advances

¹¹ Russell Hardin, "Compliance, Consent, and Legitimacy," in *The Oxford Handbook of Comparative Politics*, ed. Carles Boix and Susan Carol Stokes, vol. 4 (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2007), 236–55.

their concrete political objectives.¹² In other words, an actor does not need to wholeheartedly believe in certain normative principles to uphold them, as long as doing so is advantageous from a utilitarian perspective. This strategic nature of legitimacy makes many legitimacy-based explanations of state behavior—including ours—compatible with rational choice theories that emphasize the consequences of possessing or lacking legitimacy.¹³

How Legitimacy Matters

As mentioned above, both international legitimacy and domestic legitimacy have been subjects of intensive study; however, the connection between these two types of legitimacy requires further examination. While some scholars have begun to examine the domestic impact of international legitimacy by showing how foreign recognition can reinforce a leader's standing at home,¹⁴ this line of inquiry remains less

¹² Ian Clark, *Legitimacy in International Society*, Reprinted (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2009); Lee, "Hegemonic Authority and Domestic Legitimation."

¹³ Ian Hurd, *After Anarchy: Legitimacy and Power in the United Nations Security Council* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2007); Matthew D. Stephen, "Legitimacy Deficits of International Organizations: Design, Drift, and Decoupling at the UN Security Council," *Cambridge Review of International Affairs* 31, no. 1 (January 2, 2018): 96–121, doi:10.1080/09557571.2018.1476463.

¹⁴ Ji-Young Lee, *China's Hegemony: Four Hundred Years of East Asian Domination* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2017); Stacie E. Goddard, *When Right Makes Might: Rising Powers*

developed than the extensive research on the international consequences of possessing international legitimacy and recognition. In particular, existing studies rarely provide a systematic theoretical account of how domestic and international legitimacy concerns interact to shape elite decision making in hierarchical systems. In the following paragraphs, we aim to provide new insights into the debate on the role of legitimacy in hierarchies by establishing a link between these two bodies of scholarship.

We argue that international recognition can affect domestic legitimacy, which is crucial for the survival of rulers. The significance of international recognition as an essential source of legitimacy for a sovereign nation has been well established in the IR literature.¹⁵ Here, we do not focus on how external recognition legitimizes a state's sovereignty within the international system. Instead, we examine how it contributes to legitimizing a ruler's authority within their domestic arena.

Accordingly, our focus is on the ruler's incentives and calculations, exploring why and how they leverage international legitimacy to strengthen their domestic rule.

and World Order, Cornell Studies in Security Affairs (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2018); Strange, "Legitimacy and Hegemony in Late Imperial China."

¹⁵ J. Samuel Barkin and Bruce Cronin, "The State and the Nation: Changing Norms and the Rules of Sovereignty in International Relations," *International Organization* 48, no. 1 (1994): 107–30, doi:10.1017/S0020818300000837.

We apply the framework of signaling models in international relations to explain the strategic pursuit of legitimacy by leaders.¹⁶ In essence, international legitimacy and recognition serve as credible signals of a ruler's morality or competence to their domestic audience. The true "type" of a leader—whether moral or immoral, capable or incapable—is often private information, unobservable by the domestic audience. Therefore, to gain domestic support, leaders must demonstrate—i.e., credibly signal—that they are the "good" type. Generally, signals are deemed credible only if they can distinguish the "good" type from the "bad" type, meaning that only the "good" type of leader would be willing or able to send these signals.¹⁷ Seeking international recognition and legitimacy is precisely such an endeavor, as it requires a level of commitment that only "good" types are likely to undertake.

International Recognition and Moral Legitimacy for the Leader of a Hegemon

Domestic audiences are generally inclined to support leaders perceived as legitimate or of the "good" type. However, the priority placed on being a "good" or legitimate

¹⁶ James D. Fearon, "Signaling Foreign Policy Interests: Tying Hands Versus Sinking Costs," *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 41, no. 1 (1997): 68–90, doi:10.1177/0022002797041001004.

¹⁷ Andrew Kerner, "Why Should I Believe You? The Costs and Consequences of Bilateral Investment Treaties," *International Studies Quarterly* 53, no. 1 (March 1, 2009): 73–102, doi:10.1111/j.1468-2478.2008.01524.x.

leader differs between hegemonic and middle powers, as the sources of domestic legitimacy vary across these contexts. As summarized above, legitimacy can stem from two distinct sources: morality and performance. For leaders of a hegemonic state, demonstrating competence to achieve good performance alone is insufficient, as survival is typically not a pressing concern. Instead, they must also signal to domestic audiences their commitment to upholding and defending widely accepted norms within the hierarchy. In other words, they must embody and exemplify the moral principles underpinning the international order. Securing normative legitimacy, therefore, becomes one of the central pursuits for leaders of the hegemon, as it reassures domestic audiences of their moral leadership and alignment with these shared values.

One effective way for a hegemon leader to credibly convey their morality to domestic audiences is by demonstrating that their benevolence and integrity are widely recognized by subordinate states within the international system.¹⁸ Such diplomatic

¹⁸ G. John Ikenberry, *After Victory: Institutions, Strategic Restraint, and the Rebuilding of Order After Major Wars* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2001); Ian Clark, "Legitimacy in a Global Order," *Review of International Studies* 29, no. S1 (December 2003): 75–95, doi:10.1017/S0260210503005904; David C. Kang et al., "War, Rebellion, and Intervention under Hierarchy: Vietnam–China Relations, 1365 to 1841," *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 63, no. 4 (April 1, 2019): 896–922, doi:10.1177/0022002718772345.

successes rely on the presence of a significant number of compliant foreign states willing to acknowledge the hegemon's superiority. This prerequisite discourages hegemon leaders from fully annexing minor powers. Furthermore, international recognition is more persuasive when achieved through peaceful means rather than coercion. As a result, the hegemon often strategically restrains its expansion to preserve its international legitimacy and recognition. This, in turn, directly bolsters the leader's moral legitimacy in the eyes of domestic audiences.

While the hegemon generally exercises strategic restraint toward middle powers to gain international recognition, it may still resort to military intervention if the ruler's domestic legitimacy is endangered by challenges posed by the middle powers. These interventions are highly targeted responses to situations where the hegemon's international recognition is directly threatened, or where domestic disruptions within the middle power, if left unaddressed, could undermine the domestic legitimacy of the hegemon's ruler.¹⁹ Such calculated responses reflect how legitimacy concerns can even shape coercive actions by the hegemon.²⁰ However, it is important to note that

¹⁹ Christina Lai, "Realism Revisited: China's Status-Driven Wars against Koguryo in the Sui and Tang Dynasties," *Asian Security* 17, no. 2 (2021): 139–157, doi: 10.1080/14799855.2020.1782887.

²⁰ Clark, "Legitimacy in a Global Order"; Musgrave and Nexon, "Defending Hierarchy from the Moon to the Indian Ocean."

the hegemon's coercive interventions are highly selective and limited, making them the exception rather than the rule.

Performance Legitimacy for Leaders of Middle Powers

The security of their state is of paramount importance for domestic audiences in middle powers, so they tend to evaluate their leader's performance primarily based on their ability to safeguard state security.²¹ The ability to do this will secure that leader's performance-based legitimacy. Like their counterparts in hegemonic states, leaders of middle powers can also leverage international recognition as a credible signal to reassure domestic audiences. However, the nature of these signals differs significantly from those utilized by leaders of the hegemon. Specifically, the international recognition sought by leaders of middle powers typically comes from the hegemon. Such recognition signals that the leader enjoys the support of the most powerful actor in the system, thereby ensuring the state's survival and security.

Another measure that directly reflects a leader's competence is successful military

²¹ Lee, *China's Hegemony*; Feng Zhang, *Chinese Hegemony: Grand Strategy and International Institutions in East Asian History* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 2015); Strange, "Legitimacy and Hegemony in Late Imperial China."

conquest. Such achievements clearly differentiate capable leaders from less capable ones and can enhance rulers' performance-based legitimacy. However, middle powers are not powerful enough to defeat the hegemon militarily. As a result, other middle powers, rather than the hegemon, become natural targets for territorial expansion. This strategy can bolster a leader's authority, particularly when they are faced with domestic challenges.²² This pursuit of military achievements to demonstrate competence resonates with Richard Ned Lebow's argument that honor and standing motivate state behavior, though in our framework, the pursuit of glory serves as an instrumental signal of competence to domestic audiences rather than an end in itself.²³ In summary, the pursuit of performance-based legitimacy incentivizes middle powers to avoid directly challenging the hegemon while focusing on expanding into weaker states within the system.

Our theory thus sheds new light on the strategic behavior of middle powers, situating their deference toward hegemons and aggression toward peers within a coherent logic

²² Amy Oakes, "Diversionary War and Argentina's Invasion of the Falkland Islands," *Security Studies* 15, no. 3 (September 1, 2006): 431–63, doi:10.1080/09636410601028354; Jaroslav Tir, "Territorial Diversion: Diversionary Theory of War and Territorial Conflict," *The Journal of Politics* 72, no. 2 (2010): 413–25, doi:10.1017/s0022381609990879.

²³ Richard Ned Lebow, *Why Nations Fight: Past and Future Motives for War* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2010).

of legitimacy-seeking. This microfoundational approach complements and extends the existing literature on middle power diplomacy, which emphasizes behavioral traits such as norm entrepreneurship, coalition-building, and functional specialization.²⁴ More recent work highlights the status-sensitive and identity-driven dimensions of middle power behavior, including discursive differentiation and symbolic positioning.²⁵ These accounts offer rich insights into the identity-driven and behavioral dimensions of middle power statecraft, but often leave open the question of why particular strategies are adopted in specific relational contexts. We build on this work by identifying performance-based domestic legitimacy as a key motivator that helps explain this strategic variation. Specifically, our theory clarifies why middle power leaders are more likely to adopt cooperative postures toward the hegemon while pursuing confrontational strategies toward peer competitors. In doing so, our legitimacy-based framework offers a unifying mechanism that integrates and further specifies the strategic logic underpinning the behavioral patterns documented in the middle power literature.

²⁴ Cooper, Higgott, and Nossal, *Relocating Middle Powers*.

²⁵ Jonathan H. Ping, *Middle Power Statecraft: Indonesia, Malaysia and the Asia-Pacific* (Milton Park, Abingdon, Oxon: Taylor and Francis, 2017).

A Legitimacy Theory of Dualistic Regional Order

Taken as a whole, our theory combines the typology of legitimacy (moral vs. performance) with a signaling model grounded in rational choice. This integrated framework offers a micro-level explanation for the strategic restraint of hegemons and the expansionist behavior of middle powers toward their peers. This explanation links international legitimacy to domestic legitimacy by showing how leaders use international recognition to credibly signal their morality or competence to domestic audiences, thereby enhancing their domestic legitimacy. However, the primary concerns of domestic audiences differ between hegemons and middle powers. In hegemonic states, domestic audiences not only demand competence but also evaluate leaders' morality, whereas in middle powers, greater emphasis is placed on capability. Consequently, the credible signals employed by leaders also differ. In equilibrium, hegemons exhibit strategic restraint in their interactions with middle powers, while middle powers avoid directly challenging the hegemon, focusing instead on competition with their peers. A summary of our theory is presented in Table 1.

Table 1: A Legitimacy Theory of Dualistic Regional Order

Strategic Player	Major Source of Domestic Legitimacy	Form of Credible Signal	Behavioral Prediction
Leaders of hegemon	Moral	Reputation and recognition by middle powers as a moral exemplar in the hierarchy	Strategic restraint in actions toward middle powers with limited selective intervention
Leaders of middle powers	Performance/competence	Recognition and endorsement from the hegemon as well as military achievements	Adopting a pacifist stance toward the hegemon and pursuing conflicts with other middle powers

Legitimacy in the Hierarchy of Early East Asia

The primary source of domestic legitimacy varies between hegemons and middle powers, as the domestic audiences of each hold different expectations of their leaders regarding what is considered right and appropriate to pursue. Consequently, the rulers of hegemons and middle powers adopt divergent strategies in response to domestic demands. In this subsection, we explore this distinction theoretically by examining the sources of political legitimacy in successive Chinese dynasties compared to those of their Sinicized neighbors within the hierarchical structure of early East Asia.

Before that, we will discuss why our analysis is not anachronistic and provide

justification for the applicability of the concept of legitimacy to pre-modern East Asia.

According to Dingxin Zhao, there was a great deal of discussion in ancient China concerning the legitimacy of the state.²⁶ For example, the concept of the “Mandate of Heaven” in the *Book of Documents* (Shangshu), Confucius’ idea of the “rectification of names” (*zhengming*) and “benevolence” (*ren*), Xunzi’s assertion that “water can carry a boat but can also overturn it,” and Lu Jia’s statement that “one can conquer the world on horseback but cannot govern it on horseback” can all be regarded as theories of state power legitimacy in ancient China. Legitimacy, according to Zhao, is a fundamental issue in state politics, transcending distinctions between China and other nations, as well as between past and present times.

There is a consensus among historians that tributary missions from minor polities in East Asia enhanced the emperor’s legitimacy.²⁷ Evidence for this lies in the fact that, to attract tributary missions, Chinese emperors often reciprocated with wealth and goods far more valuable than the tributes they received, which imposed a significant fiscal burden on the empire.²⁸ In other words, what the emperors sought was not

²⁶ Ding-xin Zhao, “Guojia hefaxing he guojia shehui guanxi” [State legitimacy and state-society relations], *Academic Monthly* 48, no. 8 (2016): 166–78.

²⁷ Hongjie Zhang, *Chaogong quan: Chuantong Zhongguo de shijie zhixu* [The tribute system: The world order of traditional China] (Hunan: Yue Lu Publishing House, 2024), 271–72.

²⁸ Sheng Han, *Dongya shijie xingcheng shi lun* [On the formation of the East Asian world]

economic gain from trade but the recognition of distant peoples, even if this recognition was completely symbolic. Therefore, the behavior of Chinese emperors can only be explained by non-materialistic considerations, specifically the pursuit of legitimacy.

Morality-Based Legitimacy for Leaders of the Hegemon

Domestic audiences within a hegemon expect their rulers to be recognized not only as the most powerful leaders in the world but also as moral exemplars who uphold commonly accepted norms. The quest for legitimacy by Chinese emperors reflects these expectations. Rooted in Confucian philosophy, emperors at the apex of the hierarchy were expected to “match virtue with Heaven’s will” (*yi de pei tian*) in order to claim the Mandate of Heaven (*tian ming*).²⁹ This principle, originating in the Western Zhou Dynasty (1046–771 BCE), asserts that a ruler must embody moral excellence and benevolence to earn legitimacy. It defines the moral responsibilities a ruler must uphold, including obligations toward foreign subordinates. According to

(Shanghai: Fudan University Press, 2009), 41–43.

²⁹ Daron Acemoglu and James A. Robinson, “Culture, Institutions, and Social Equilibria: A Framework,” *Journal of Economic Literature* 63, no. 2 (June 2025): 637–92, doi:10.1257/jel.20241680.

this principle, a ruler's legitimacy is not derived from force or lineage but rather from their moral character aligning with the will of Heaven. A subtle yet critical implication of this principle is that emperors who fail to align their virtue with the will of Heaven lose the mandate and could justifiably be overthrown, regardless of their lineage. This serves as the moral justification for the "revolution" of Tang and Wu (*tangwu geming*, a term from the *Book of Changes/I Ching*), the first rebellions in China which overthrew the Xia and Shang dynasties in approximately 1600 BCE and 1046 BCE, respectively.³⁰ This potential threat incentivized emperors to reinforce their normative legitimacy by demonstrating international recognition as virtuous leaders.

In doing so, the emperor sought to preserve the existence of middle powers in the system instead of annexing them and avoid expansionist actions that could undermine the empire's international legitimacy and recognition. Emperors refrained from territorial expansion into tributary states *not* because they did not consider these territories as part of their realm, but because they needed recognition from the tributary states. In a later subsection, we will elaborate on why and how international

³⁰ Zhaoguang Ge, *Xing si shen yi: Shenme shi Zhong-Ri chuantong zhengzhi wenhua de jiegouxing chayi* [Similar in form, different in spirit: What are the structural differences between Chinese and Japanese traditional political cultures?] (Beijing: Social Sciences Academic Press, 2024), 8.

recognition matters for the hegemon. Here, we focus on why the hegemon's strategic restraint was not driven by any subjective boundary or confinement. Prior to the introduction of the Westphalian principles to East Asia, mutually exclusive territorial delineation was largely absent in the region, with Edo Japan (1600-1868) being the only exception.³¹ In the Confucian worldview, while there was a conceptual distinction between the Civilized (*hua*) and the Barbarians (*yi*), this boundary was fluid, dynamic, and subject to change.³² Ideally, the emperor was expected to transform the Barbarians into the Civilized, not through military conquest, but through teaching and enlightenment (*jiaohua*). Simply put, there was no fixed limit to the emperor's perceived realm because in early East Asia, none of the polities maintained clearly delineated borders like those of modern nation-states. From the emperor's perspective, all territories "under heaven" (*tianxia*) belonged to him (*putian zhixia, mofei wangtu*).

As mentioned above, exceptions did exist: Chinese emperors were compelled to respond with military measures if their domestic legitimacy was endangered due to

³¹ Naosuke Mukoyama, "The Eastern Cousins of European Sovereign States? The Development of Linear Borders in Early Modern Japan," *European Journal of International Relations* 29, no. 2 (June 1, 2023): 255–82, doi:10.1177/13540661221133206.

³² Han, *Dongya shijie xingcheng shi lun*, 5–25.

crises involving middle powers. This could arise from two possible causes. First, a middle power might openly challenge China's hegemonic position within the system. While, in the equilibrium of our model, middle powers were expected to remain obedient to the hegemon, an exogenous increase in a middle power's capabilities could encourage them to challenge China openly.³³ This intention would prompt military intervention by China to defend its international recognition, which was critical for the emperor's domestic legitimacy. However, this scenario was rare due to the generally large and apparent disparity between China and its neighbors. Second, and more likely, domestic changes within a middle power—particularly usurpation—might compel the Chinese emperor to act forcefully to restore order, because an unpunished usurper risked encouraging rebellions within China itself. In both scenarios, China employed military intervention to safeguard its international, and eventually, domestic legitimacy.

Performance-Based Legitimacy for Leaders of Middle Powers

In contrast, domestic audiences of a middle power in early East Asia placed greater

³³ Dominic D. P. Johnson and Dominic Tierney, "The Rubicon Theory of War: How the Path to Conflict Reaches the Point of No Return," *International Security* 36, no. 1 (2011): 7–40.

emphasis on the performance legitimacy of their leaders. This difference in the preferences of domestic audiences originates from the fact that none of these minor polities adopted the principle of “matching virtue with Heaven’s will.” According to Zhaoguang Ge, a prominent Chinese historian, this is a “structural and fundamental difference” in political culture and political legitimacy between ancient China and Japan.³⁴ In China, rulers were expected to be moral, otherwise they would lose the Mandate of Heaven and risked being overthrown. Whereas rulers in Japan, for example, did not need to match their virtue with Heaven’s will, because the rulers themselves, who were believed to descend from the gods, were direct representatives of Heaven.³⁵ Therefore, their claim was not based on morality but on the bloodline. The Japanese imperial family line has never been broken and persists into modern times. Free from the dynastic cycles of imperial China, rulers of Japan did not need to demonstrate virtue to guarantee domestic legitimacy. Interestingly, aristocrats in ancient Japan also claimed descent from the gods, though of a lower rank compared to the emperor’s divine ancestor. This myth reinforced the authority of the aristocrats, hindering centralization and empowering domestic challengers.³⁶ As a result,

³⁴ Ge, *Xing si shen yi*, 9–10.

³⁵ Manabu Waida, “Sacred Kingship in Early Japan: A Historical Introduction,” *History of Religions* 15, no. 4 (1976): 319–42.

³⁶ Ge, *Xing si shen yi*, 13–15.

incompetent rulers in Japan often found their authority fragile: they might retain the symbolic throne due to their divine bloodline but would have to relinquish their de facto authority to govern.

This sharp contrast in the source of political legitimacy did not exclusively exist between China and Japan, but also between China and middle powers in the Korean Peninsula. The ruling families of Goguryeo, Baekje, and Silla, much like their counterparts in Japan, maintained unbroken lines of succession for hundreds of years until their eventual demise. These rulers claimed divine ancestry, and their domestic hierarchies were structured around birthright statuses, creating political dynamics similar to those of Japan.³⁷ For instance, Silla's bone-rank system categorized elites into sacred bone, true bone, and head-rank groups based on heredity, with sacred bone and true bone signifying royal lineage. Only aristocrats from these two ranks were eligible to ascend to the throne. Consequently, when these two groups rebelled, they could only justify their revolt by citing the incompetence of the incumbent ruler, as both the rebels and the incumbents shared the same hallowed blood, which already symbolized their moral mandate.³⁸ In other words, the rulers of these middle powers

³⁷ Namio Egami, *Kiba Minzoku Kokka* (Tokyo: Heibonsha, 1991).

³⁸ Michael J. Seth, *A History of Korea: From Antiquity to the Present* (Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield, 2010), 39–40.

were less concerned about challenges to their moral virtue and more focused on proving their competency.

Testable Implications

Based on our theoretical framework, we can derive the following hypotheses to be evaluated against empirical evidence from early East Asia, a typical hierarchy that consisted of China and its neighbors.

Hypothesis 1: Conflicts involving China, the hegemon, and middle powers were relatively rare in early East Asia, with Chinese empires seldom initiating conflicts with middle powers.

Hypothesis 2: Conflicts between or among middle powers were more frequent in early East Asia.

Empirical Evidence: War and Peace in Early East Asia

In this section, we present empirical evidence that sheds light on the dualistic nature of the regional order in early East Asia, spanning the years 345-700 CE. Using first-hand historical sources, we demonstrate that wars involving China—the region’s hegemon—were infrequent. In contrast, conflicts among middle powers were prevalent. The hegemonic peace fostered by the Chinese-led hierarchy primarily existed between China and its tributary states, not between the tributary subjects themselves. Our empirical data suggest that despite adopting Chinese institutions and culture, the middle-power states engaged in intense competition for dominance.

Describing the Data

Samples. Our analysis is based on the historical context of Northeast Asia from the 4th to the 7th century CE, a period marked by frequent interactions among Chinese dynasties, Korean kingdoms, and Yamato Japan. The geographic scope of our analysis includes Korea, Japan, and Northeast China, where Chinese dynasties, the three kingdoms of Korea (Goguryeo, Baekje, and Silla), Korean minor states (e.g., the Gaya Confederacy in southern Korea), and Yamato Japan (officially named Wa until late the

600s) interacted intensively.

The geographical and temporal scope of our study has garnered increasing scholarly attention.³⁹ We selected this period and area as our empirical focus because contemporaneous historical records from China, Korea, and Japan are available, which allow for cross-referencing and the construction of a reliable dataset on conflicts. Recognizing the potential biases in any single source—such as biases in recording which side instigated the conflict—it is essential to use multiple sources to construct the dataset. Notably, the low frequency of wars initiated by China is corroborated not only by Chinese records but also by Korean and Japanese historical accounts.

Data sources. We draw on first-hand historical sources, including *The History of the Three Kingdoms (samguk sagi)* of Korea, *The Orthodox Histories (zhengshi)* of China, and *The Chronicles of Japan (nihon shoki)*, which collectively provide a comprehensive account of the interactions within the regional system. We chose *The History of the Three Kingdoms (samguk sagi)* of Korea, compiled by 1145 CE, as the major source

³⁹ Chin-Hao Huang and David C. Kang, *State Formation through Emulation: The East Asian Model* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2022).

for our dataset in order to avoid any pro-hegemon bias that might be introduced by using *The Orthodox Histories (zhengshi) of China*. Specifically, we ensured that all war accounts involving China from this Korean source are included in our dataset to mitigate potential biases possibly present in Chinese records. The invasion of Goguryeo by the Chinese Tang dynasty allied with Silla in 667 is the only entry for a war initiated by China recorded in Korean sources but not in any Chinese sources. However, this entry does not represent the onset of a new war, as it is clearly the continuation of a conflict initiated in 666. Moreover, *The History of the Three Kingdoms of Korea* treats the three major kingdoms, namely Goguryeo, Baekje, and Silla, as equally legitimate polities, avoiding positive or negative biases toward any of them. Therefore, this Korean record will serve as the baseline data source, supplemented by Chinese and Japanese documents.

From *The Orthodox Histories of China*, we focus on records that cover interactions among Chinese dynasties, Korean kingdoms, and Japan on the Korean Peninsula. Sources that cover these interactions include *Records of the Three Kingdoms* (compiled in the 280s CE, same below), *The Book of the Later Han* (445), *The Book of Song* (488), *The Book of Southern Qi* (537), *The Book of Wei* (554), *The Book of Liang* (636), *The Book of Chen* (636), *The Book of Northern Qi* (636), *The Book of Zhou* (636), *The Book*

of Sui (636), *The Book of Jin* (648), *The History of the Southern Dynasties* (659), *The History of the Northern Dynasties* (659), *The Old Book of Tang* (956), and *The New Book of Tang* (1060). *The Chronicles of Japan*, that finish in 720 CE, is a less reliable source due to its exaggeration of reign lengths, but it still provides key information on Japan's military presence on the peninsula during the period 300-663 CE. To improve validity and minimize source bias, we triangulate across these accounts throughout the process of constructing the dataset.

Definition of China and “international relations,” 300-700 CE. We agree that pre-modern China differed markedly from the People's Republic of China as we know it today.⁴⁰ In our analysis, we do not consider China as a monolithic or insular power within the regional hierarchy. Indeed, China was divided into the Northern and Southern dynasties during the period 420-589 CE. However, there is little dispute that in pre-modern East Asia, including the period under study, a dominant power based in China proper exerted profound influence on its neighbors in science, technology, and culture.⁴¹ Even during periods of temporary fragmentation, the various factions—

⁴⁰ Victoria Tin-bor Hui, “‘Getting Asia Right’: De-Essentializing China's Hegemony in Historical Asia,” *International Theory* 15, no. 3 (November 2023): 485, doi:10.1017/S1752971923000143.

⁴¹ Huang Chin-Hao and David C. Kang, “State Formation in Korea and Japan, 400–800 CE: Emulation and Learning, Not Bellicist Competition,” *International Organization* 76, no. 1 (2022): 1–

regardless of whether their ruling elites were ethnically Han Chinese—claimed to represent the orthodox (*zhengtong*) lineage of this polity. Even nomadic peoples who conquered the whole or a part of China proper actively sought to inherit its norms and culture through Sinicizing reforms.⁴² This dominance was also widely recognized by the polity’s neighbors. For instance, all monarchs of tributary states referred to themselves as “subjects” (*chen*) in diplomatic exchanges with the emperor (*huangdi*), a title reserved only for those who claimed the mandate of this polity, including leaders of the Northern and Southern Dynasties. Thus, “China” in this context extends beyond a mere geographical concept encompassing the territory of contemporary China. It represents a materially and culturally dominant power—a hegemon in a hierarchical order—whose superiority, though sometimes contested internally by various factions, was broadly acknowledged by other smaller polities of East Asia.

Another concern with using modern social science concepts to analyze pre-modern state behavior is the question of what constituted “international relations” during 300–700 CE. Specifically, to what extent did the leaders of China consider their

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⁴² Joy Chen, Erik H. Wang, and Xiaoming Zhang, “From Powerholders to Stakeholders: State-Building with Elite Compensation in Early Medieval China,” *American Journal of Political Science* 69, no. 2 (2025): 607–23, doi:10.1111/ajps.12888.

interactions with tributary states as “international relations”? Furthermore, did they recognize other factions within China as equal entities, thereby considering interactions with them as “international relations” as well? From first-hand historical records, it is evident that Chinese emperors—whether ruling the Northern or Southern Dynasties—regarded their interactions with the Korean kingdoms and Japan as “diplomacy,” with their superiority widely acknowledged by tributary states.⁴³ In other words, interactions with these minor polities resemble relations between a hegemon and subordinate entities in a hierarchy.⁴⁴

In contrast, relations between different factions within China—namely the Northern and Southern Dynasties—were fundamentally different. Neither faction recognized the other as the legitimate ruler of the Middle Kingdom. The Northern Dynasties denounced the Southern Dynasties as “Island Barbarians” (*daoyi*), while the Southern Dynasties referred to the North as “captives” (*suolu*) in their official Orthodox Histories.⁴⁵ As such, their interactions more closely resembled a civil war, in which competing factions vied for control of the same country while sharing a common cultural identity. It is important to note that none of the strategic actors discussed in

⁴³ Han, *Dongya shijie xingcheng shi lun*.

⁴⁴ Kang, *East Asia Before the West*.

⁴⁵ *Book of Wei*, Volume 85, 86; *Book of Song*, Volume 95.

this analysis—including China, as well as middle powers in Korea and Japan—can be classified as a nation-state, which is a modern construct. While these are states, they do not fit the definition of nation-states.

Definition of war onset. We construct our dataset according to the following procedure. We define an entry as a war if it contains keywords indicating military actions such as “战” (war), “发兵” (dispatch troops), “伐” (invade), and “破” (defeat). We clearly distinguish between war initiation and war continuation in our dataset. This distinction is straightforward to make, as most of the conflicts described in historical records were essentially border skirmishes that lasted less than one year. For large-scale wars, historical records clearly indicate the timing of their conclusion. For example, the large-scale invasion of Baekje by Goguryeo in 475, during which Goguryeo successfully occupied Baekje’s capital, is recorded as follows in *The History of the Three Kingdoms*, Volume 18: “In September, the [Goguryeo] king led an army of 30,000 to invade Baekje, capturing its capital, Hansung. They killed its king, Buyeo Kyung, and took 8,000 men and women as prisoners before returning.” Here, the term “returning” serves as a clear indication of the war’s conclusion. There are 158 entries for war actions, including 7 for continued wars. In other words, the majority of wars ended within the same year of their initiation.

Scale of conflicts. From historical records, we can determine the scale of 11 conflicts involving middle powers and the number of casualties inflicted. The sizes of the forces involved in these conflicts ranged from a few thousand to 30,000 troops. While we lack detailed records for other middle power conflicts, we can infer that they were of a smaller scale, as they were mostly border skirmishes that typically lasted less than a year.

The scale of all campaigns launched by the Sui and Tang dynasties against middle powers in Korea is also documented. The invasions of Goguryeo by the Sui and Tang during the first half of the 7th century were larger in scale, involving at least 100,000 personnel on the Chinese side and 150,000–300,000 from Goguryeo. The multiple campaigns waged by the Sui from 611 to 614 and by the Tang from 644 to 666 can be understood as part of larger, ongoing wars fought over short periods. However, we still code each campaign as a separate war because each had a clear outcome in terms of victory and concluded with a pause in hostilities. While this coding scheme significantly inflates the number of wars initiated by China, it does not undermine our inferences. In fact, this inflated count would bias the results against our theoretical expectation, as China would appear even more pacifist if all these campaigns were coded as a single war.

We construct a time series of conflict *onset* recorded by the Chinese, Japanese, and Korean historical sources. The series starts in the year 345, prior to which records concerning Baekje and Silla are regarded as less reliable. Baekje migrated south in the year 345 and started to pay tribute to the Chinese dynasties thereafter, hence it was recorded in the *Orthodox Histories of China* from 345. In other words, we can perform cross-reference checks using both Chinese and Korean sources. Before 345, there were seven wars between Baekje and Silla recorded in *The History of the Three Kingdoms of Korea*. The series ends in 700 CE, though no wars in Northeast Asia were recorded after 667 CE (see Figure 1). The time series reveals that there were 151 wars recorded in the period under study, with wars breaking out over 106 years between 345 and 700 CE. This appears to contradict the Confucian long peace theory and suggests that the region may have been less peaceful than is widely accepted by many students of IR in historical East Asia. However, upon closer examination of the warring parties, a more nuanced pattern emerges that does not necessarily nullify the Confucian long peace theory.

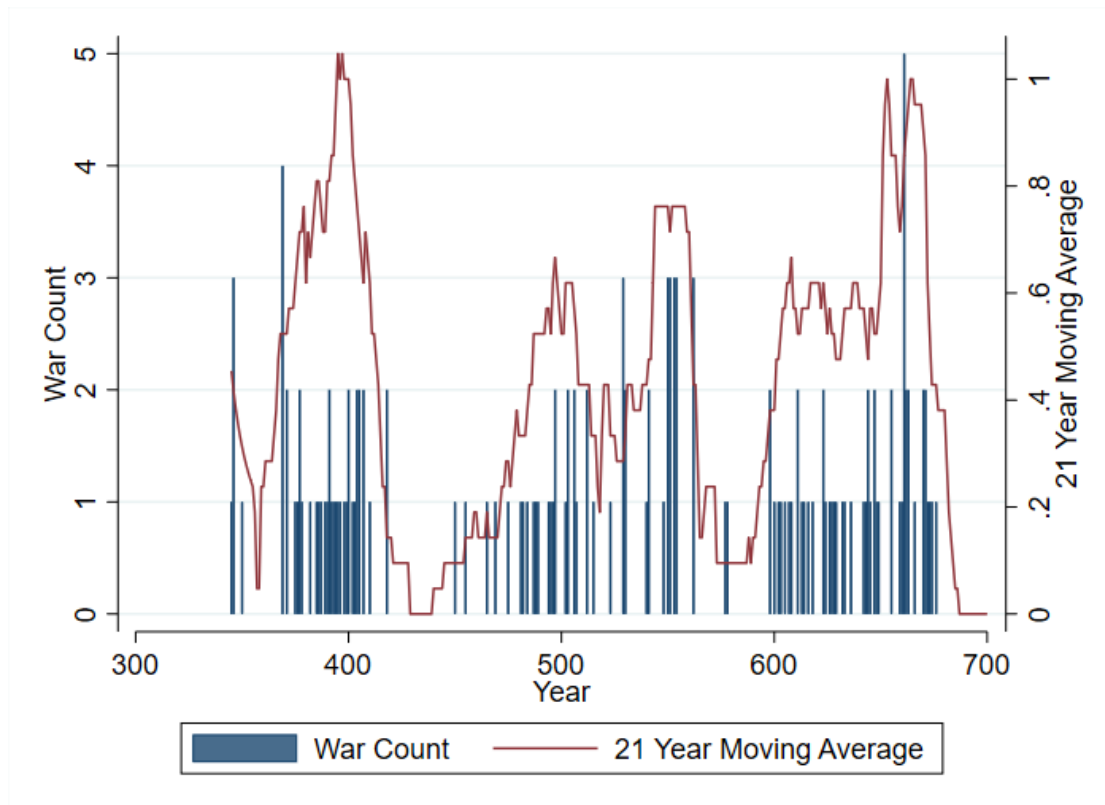


Figure 1: Time Series of Interstate Conflicts in Northeast Asia, 345-700 CE

Testing Hypothesis 1: The Rarity of War Involving China

First, most of the wars during the period under study did not involve Chinese dynasties, which constituted the undisputed hegemon in the hierarchical system (see Figure 2). Prior to the reunification of China by the Sui dynasty in 581, no Chinese dynasty, including the Northern and Southern dynasties, both of which received tributes regularly from the Korean kingdoms and Japan, had ever initiated a single war against its neighbors in Northeast Asia. Instead, all six wars launched from contemporary China's territory against the Korean kingdoms were instigated by the autonomous nomadic warlords, namely the Murong clan, which had been active near

the Korean Peninsula for centuries.

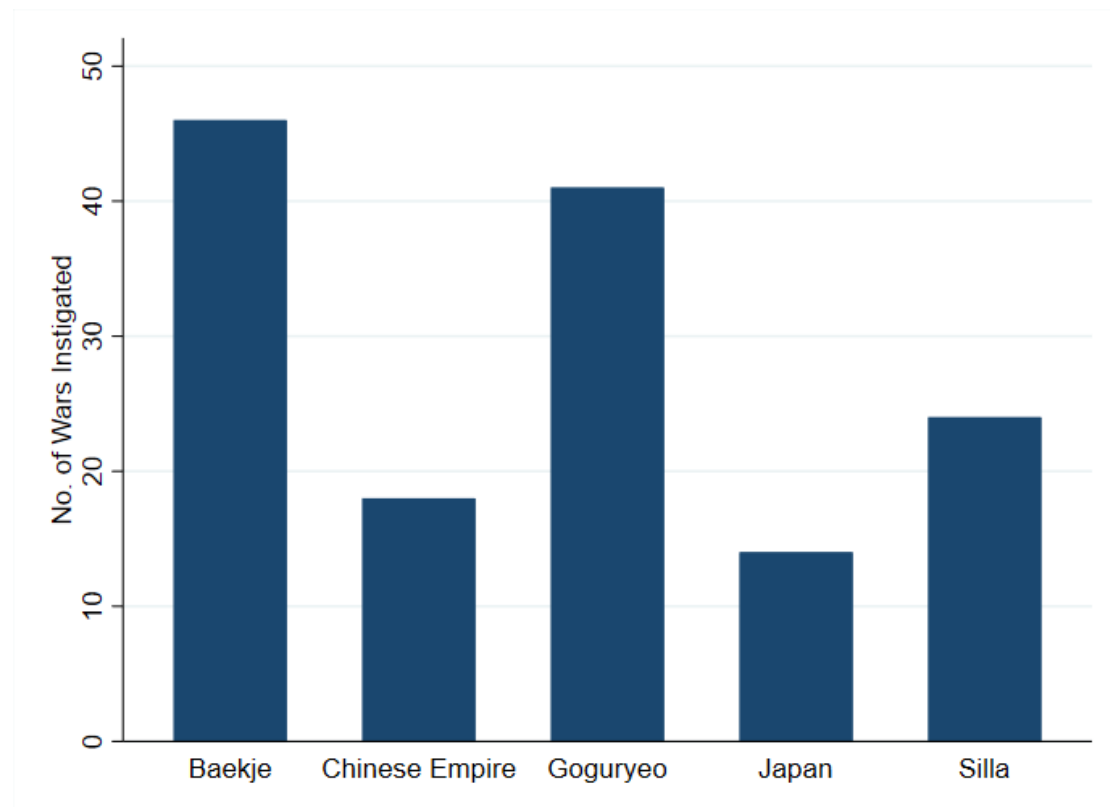


Figure 2: Number of Wars Instigated by Chinese Empire and Middle Powers, 345-700 CE

Following China's unification, the Sui and Tang dynasties initiated limited military campaigns against the Korean kingdoms—four and fourteen times, respectively—markedly fewer than the conflicts instigated by the three Korean kingdoms. Although the number of wars initiated by Chinese empires is slightly higher than those initiated by Japan, we still cannot conclude that Japan was more pacifist than China during this period. First, Figure 2 adopts a coding scheme that may overestimate the actual number of wars initiated by China. Under this scheme, any suspension of military operations, regardless of the duration of the truce, results in the subsequent campaign

being classified as a new onset of war. Alternatively, certain campaigns could be grouped into a single war based on continuity under the same commanders. Specifically, the two campaigns initiated by the Sui against Goguryeo in 613 and 614, the four campaigns launched by the Tang against Goguryeo, Baekje, and Japan in 661–663, and the three campaigns by the Tang against the remaining forces of Goguryeo in 671–673 could each be considered as single wars. Using this alternative approach would reduce the number of wars attributed to the Sui and Tang from 18 to 12, while the count of wars initiated by Yamato Japan would remain unchanged at 13. This alternative coding scheme would also have no impact on the frequency of wars initiated by the three Korean kingdoms.

More importantly, wars initiated by Chinese empires were not necessarily expansionist in nature. For example, the Sui dynasty's first war in 598 CE was a response to Goguryeo's earlier surprise raid. Subsequent invasions by the Sui targeted Goguryeo's defiance of its tributary obligations, including refusal to pay tributes. Similarly, the Tang dynasty's campaigns against Goguryeo, which began in 645 CE, were a response to General Yeon Gaesomun's usurpation of the throne in Goguryeo. These interventions, akin to later Ming and Qing invasions of Vietnam, were driven by a desire to restore the legitimate ruler rather than to annex territory. On the other

hand, Japan's territorial interest in the Korean Peninsula was evident and long-lasting.

Hence, the Chinese empire was still more pacifist than Yamato Japan (see further discussions below).

China's relative pacifism is further evidenced by its post-war policies. Despite decisive military victories over Baekje and Goguryeo, Tang China refrained from incorporating the Korean Peninsula into its centralized prefecture-county system (*junxianzhi*). Instead, it established commanderies (*dudufu*) that relied on local elites for governance. Notably, even Silla, a fully independent state, hosted such commanderies, underscoring their symbolic rather than administrative significance. By the late 7th century, Tang China had relinquished control over the former territories of Baekje to Silla and those of Goguryeo to Balhae, despite possessing the economic and military capacity to dominate the region. In summary, wars involving Chinese dynasties were rare and concentrated in the period from 640 to 670 CE, supporting our Hypothesis 1.

The existing literature also underscores the rarity of interstate wars initiated by the hegemon within a Chinese-dominated hierarchy. The Confucian long peace theory, which emphasizes the pacifying effect of shared Confucian norms and culture, finds

support in historical records from China and elsewhere. For example, the Choson Dynasty of Korea reigned for over 500 years without engaging in a single war with the unified Chinese empire, namely under the Ming (1368-1644) and Qing (1644-1911) dynasties.⁴⁶ Before seizing China proper, the Manchu people invaded Korea twice in the first half of the 17th century in an effort to subjugate the latter and cut its tributary ties with Ming China. Compared to its predecessor the Ming, Qing China's dominance in the region was more coercive, though at the same time the Manchus strategically embraced Confucian norms and practices to enhance their legitimacy as the rulers of China and the leaders of the Confucian world in East Asia.⁴⁷ Similarly, interstate wars between Vietnam and its northern neighbor were exceedingly rare, with only two incidents recorded: one in 1406-1407 with Ming China, and the other in 1788-1789 with Qing China, both of which involved Chinese intervention to support the incumbent regime against usurpers.⁴⁸ In sharp contrast to Europe, where external wars were common and had profound implications for institutional development, violent conflicts in pre-modern East Asia were largely internally oriented, mostly

⁴⁶ David C. Kang, Meredith Shaw, and Ronan Tse-min Fu, "Measuring War in Early Modern East Asia, 1368–1841: Introducing Chinese and Korean Language Sources," *International Studies Quarterly* 60, no. 4 (2016): 766–77.

⁴⁷ Andrew Phillips, "Contesting the Confucian Peace: Civilization, Barbarism and International Hierarchy in East Asia," *European Journal of International Relations* 24, no. 4 (2018): 740–64.

⁴⁸ Kang et al., "War, Rebellion, and Intervention under Hierarchy."

involving domestic rebellions.⁴⁹

Testing Hypothesis 2: The Frequent Occurrence of War among Middle Powers

While Chinese dynasties typically maintained peaceful relations with their neighbors, the secondary states of Northeast Asia frequently engaged in warfare to secure their survival and pursue territorial ambitions. Quantitative evidence highlights the stark contrast between the hegemon's relative pacifism and the belligerence of middle powers. As shown in Figure 2, Baekje was the most aggressive of all, initiating 46 wars, closely followed by Goguryeo with 41. These figures far exceed the number of wars instigated by the Chinese (18), all of which were launched by the unified Sui and Tang dynasties from the late 6th century onward.

Table 2 provides a cross-tabulation analysis of conflict instigators and targets involving the four middle powers in Northeast Asia. Goguryeo and Baekje each instigated 40 wars against other secondary states in the region, albeit with differing targets; Goguryeo primarily targeted Baekje, while Baekje mainly sought to expand

⁴⁹ Mark Dincecco and Yuhua Wang, "Violent Conflict and Political Development over the Long Run: China versus Europe," *Annual Review of Political Science* 21 (2018): 341–58.

toward Silla. This pattern reiterates the superior war capabilities of Goguryeo and Baekje relative to Silla, as substantiated by historical studies.⁵⁰ During the study period, Japan and Baekje formed an alliance, with Japan refraining from invading Baekje. However, Japan did invade Silla 11 times, rendering Silla the most vulnerable state among the four. As a result, from the mid-7th century, Silla had to rely on the support of an external balancer, Tang China, to guarantee its survival.

Despite the overarching peace upheld by the Chinese dynasties, middle powers in Northeast Asia, particularly Goguryeo and Baekje, were locked in persistent warfare as they vied for dominance and resources. The territorial ambitions of Silla and Japan were also substantial, though their less developed institutions limited their capacity to mobilize for war. Yamato Japan, for instance, sought to consolidate its hold over the southern Korean Peninsula, an area rich in iron resources essential for producing agricultural tools and weaponry.⁵¹ Similarly, Silla's territorial ambitions were evident from its military annexation of the Gaya Confederacy in the 6th century, a move that

⁵⁰ Jun Yang, *Gaogouli minzu yu guojia de xingcheng he yanbian* [The formation and evolution of the Goguryeo nation and state] (Beijing: China Social Science Press, 2006); Jun Yang, Fushun Gao, and Weigong Jiang, *Gaogouli Guanzhi Yanjiu* [A study of Goguryeo's bureaucratic institutions] (Jilin: Jilin University Press, 2014).

⁵¹ Song-Nai Rhee et al., "Korean Contributions to Agriculture, Technology, and State Formation in Japan: Archaeology and History of an Epochal Thousand Years, 400 B.C.–A.D. 600," *Asian Perspectives* 46, no. 2 (2007): 404–59.

provoked fierce opposition from Baekje and its ally, Japan, both of whom had traditionally regarded Gaya as lying within their sphere of influence.

The data presented in Table 2 and Figures 1 and 2 reveal a stark dichotomy in conflict dynamics within the early East Asian hierarchical order. Middle powers frequently engaged in warfare against one another while avoiding direct confrontation with the Chinese hegemon. This pattern confirms Hypotheses 1 and 2. The contrast between the middle powers' frequent conflicts and the hegemon's relative pacifism reflects the fundamentally different incentives driving these actors.

Table 2: Instigators and Targets of Wars between Middle Powers in Early East Asia

		Target				
		Goguryeo	Baekje	Silla	Japan	Sum
Instigator	Goguryeo		25	15	0	40
	Baekje	14		26	0	40
	Silla	4	7		1	12
	Japan	2	0	11		13
	Sum	20	32	52	1	

Mechanism: How Legitimacy Matters

In this section, we provide qualitative evidence to illustrate how concerns about domestic legitimacy motivate hegemonic and middle powers within a hierarchy to seek different forms of international recognition, and how this results in distinct

behaviors regarding peace and war. For both hegemonic and middle powers, international recognition serves as a credible signal of legitimate leadership. However, the sources of domestic legitimacy differ between the two. We begin by discussing how the desire for domestic legitimacy dissuaded Chinese dynasties from pursuing military expansion. Following that, we present a case study of Yamato Japan to illustrate how a similar concern for legitimacy prompted middle powers to engage in warfare with their rivals.

The Hegemon's Quest for Legitimacy

China's self-restraint, despite its unmatched power within the regional hierarchy, can be understood through the lens of domestic legitimacy. To qualify as the leader of a hegemon in the eyes of domestic audiences, the Chinese emperor not only needed to demonstrate capability through material power but also had to act as a moral exemplar, upholding norms commonly accepted in the Confucian world. This quality could best be demonstrated by obtaining international recognition from middle powers, rendering aggressive territorial expansion counterproductive and annexation unnecessary. Even in exceptional cases where military intervention was employed by the Chinese empire, such actions were carefully calibrated to address specific threats to the emperor's domestic legitimacy.

The international respect and recognition an emperor garnered could significantly bolster their reputation and authority as a morally legitimate leader within the domestic sphere. This dynamic is aptly illustrated in the case of Liu Yu, the founder of the Liu Song Dynasty (420–589 CE). Born into a low-status family and ascending to the throne through usurpation, Liu Yu faced widespread skepticism from the aristocracy regarding his legitimacy as the Son of Heaven (*tianzi*). This skepticism was not rooted in doubts about his capability—his military achievements in external wars had proven his competence—but rather in moral concerns, particularly regarding his execution of two emperors of the preceding Eastern Jin Dynasty.⁵² Such actions blatantly violated Confucian ethics, which emphasize loyalty and obedience to the emperor. Consequently, after seizing the throne, Liu Yu urgently needed to consolidate his rule by bolstering his *moral* legitimacy on the domestic front.

It was during this period, when Liu Yu's domestic legitimacy was under scrutiny, that Zan, the King of Japan, sent a tributary envoy in 421 CE. This was the first diplomatic visit from Japan to China in over a century. The visit was highly valued by Emperor Liu Yu, who faced resistance from aristocrats unwilling to accept a ruler of humble origins and questionable moral conduct. The willingness of distant foreign states to

⁵² *History of the Southern Dynasties*, Volume 1.

pay tribute was leveraged by Liu Yu to affirm his virtue and legitimacy, despite his humble origins and act of regicide.⁵³ In a reciprocal gesture, Liu Yu gratefully bestowed titles upon Zan. At the same time, Liu Yu elevated the ranks of the kings of Goguryeo and Baekje, seeking to encourage them to follow the example of Yamato Japan and promptly send tributary envoys. These moves were intended to bolster Liu Yu's domestic legitimacy further.⁵⁴ In essence, the existence of foreign tributary states serves as a credible signal of the emperor's moral legitimacy. Consequently, the hegemon, despite possessing unrivaled power, had little incentive to annex these states.

In sharp contrast to Liu Yu, Wang Mang's lack of international recognition undermined his moral legitimacy in the domestic sphere, contributing to the collapse of his rule in China. Wang Mang was a usurper who established the short-lived Xin Dynasty (9–23 CE). Asserting his vision of unification (*yitong*), Wang Mang downgraded the lordship ranks of neighboring states, believing none of their leaders deserved the title of “king” (*wang*), and imposed derogatory names upon these states. A notable instance of his policy was the renaming of Goguryeo from Gao Gou Li to

⁵³ Chunren Henei, *Wa No Go O* [The five kings of Wa] (Beijing: Social Sciences Academic Press, 2021), 45.

⁵⁴ *Book of Song*, Volume 97.

Xia Gou Li. While “Gao” has a positive connotation of “high” in Chinese, “Xia” represents “low.” Such arbitrary actions, coupled with his expansionist and oppressive policies, incited widespread armed resistance among Xin China’s neighbors, particularly Goguryeo.⁵⁵ It is important to note that Goguryeo’s resistance was not an opportunistic act driven by a desire to exploit the weakening of the central power. The renaming of Goguryeo occurred early in Wang Mang’s reign, at a time when the Xin Dynasty’s power was at its peak, Wang Mang’s domestic authority had not yet been challenged, and there were no domestic rebellions. Furthermore, Goguryeo’s resistance did not begin until after the renaming incident and the military oppression imposed by the Xin Dynasty.⁵⁶ In essence, Goguryeo’s resistance was a reaction to the Xin Dynasty’s expansionism, rather than a revisionist attempt to exploit its weaknesses.

These conflicts not only destroyed the Xin Dynasty’s international recognition but also undermined Wang Mang’s domestic legitimacy. The uprising of barbarians in all four directions (*siyi*) was interpreted as a sign that Heaven favored Wang Mang’s challenger, Liu Xiu, who later unified China and established the Eastern Han Dynasty

⁵⁵ *Book of Han*, Volume 99.

⁵⁶ *Book of Later Han*, Volume 85.

(25-220 CE).⁵⁷ Indeed, a Chinese emperor who lost the trust of neighboring states was typically regarded as illegitimate and immoral by domestic audiences. Learning from Wang Mang's mistakes, Liu Xiu restored the kingship of leaders in neighboring states, including those on the Korean Peninsula and Japan.

The motivation to maintain tributary states rather than annexing them is not exclusive to China. Indeed, both Japan and Vietnam once established their own tributary systems. For instance, during the Tokugawa period, Japan constructed a hierarchy reminiscent of the Chinese tributary system. Under this system—referred to as the “Little China” (*xiao zhonghua*) system by historians, Tokugawa Japan included the Ainu people to the north and the Ryukyu Kingdom to the south as their tributary subjects. Mirroring their counterparts within the Chinese-led hierarchy, these subjects were expected to pay tributes to the Shogunate and acknowledge the Shogun as the supreme sovereign. The Shogun's receipt of tributes from these subjects and their recognition of his authority served to consolidate his position as the legitimate ruler of Japan.⁵⁸ Analogous to China, Tokugawa Japan exhibited little motivation to fully integrate these subjects, despite having the capability to do so. Their annexation only

⁵⁷ *Book of Later Han*, Volume 1.

⁵⁸ Xiuwu Chen, *Jindai Riben guojia yishi de xingcheng* [The formation of modern Japanese national consciousness] (Beijing: The Commercial Press, 2008).

occurred when the threat from European powers became imminent in the second half of the 19th century. Simply put, these historical cases underscore the fact that preserving, rather than annexing, middle powers can play a critical role in enhancing the domestic legitimacy of the leader of a hegemonic power.

Military Intervention to Defend Legitimacy

Despite its general pacifism, China did intervene militarily under specific conditions that threatened its legitimacy. Two scenarios are particularly notable: open defiance from a tributary state, which could damage the hegemon's international legitimacy, and illegitimate leadership changes within tributary states, which could directly impact the emperor's domestic legitimacy. In both cases, military action served to reassert the emperor's rightful authority, safeguarding international and, eventually, domestic legitimacy.

Addressing Defiance. China's military interventions often followed instances of explicit defiance by tributary states, where challenges to its supremacy undermined the hegemon's international recognition. One illustrative example is the Sui Dynasty's response to Goguryeo's pre-emptive strike on the Sui border in 598 CE. This act of

aggression occurred shortly after Emperor Yang Jian (Emperor Wen of Sui) had formally conferred the title of king on Yuan, the ruler of Goguryeo. The strike was perceived not only as a military threat but also as a betrayal of China's hierarchical authority, prompting Yang Jian to retaliate with a full-scale invasion. Although the campaign ultimately failed, it coerced King Yuan into issuing a formal apology and resuming tribute payments.

Subsequent challenges by Goguryeo led Yang Jian's successor, Emperor Yang Guang (Emperor Yang of Sui), to launch additional invasions. These efforts, while costly and largely unsuccessful, were aimed at restoring the hegemon's political standing within the international order. Such acts of defiance were seen as direct repudiations of China's authority, tarnishing the emperor's image not only among tributary states but also within the domestic sphere. Military responses to these provocations were thus framed as necessary to uphold the emperor's international legitimacy as the supreme leader and, fundamentally, his domestic legitimacy as the ultimate sovereign.

Responding to Usurpation. China also intervened militarily when leadership changes in tributary states were deemed illegitimate. Within the tributary system, rulers of middle powers relied on the emperor's recognition to legitimize their

authority. Usurpations disrupted this order, challenging the norms that underpinned the system. Moreover, tolerating such disruptions risked emboldening rebellious factions within China, threatening the emperor's own domestic authority.

The Tang Dynasty's campaigns against Goguryeo in the mid-7th century provide a compelling example. In 642 CE, General Yeon Gaesomun orchestrated a coup, assassinating the reigning king and seizing control of the kingdom. The Tang emperor viewed this act not only as a violation of Confucian norms but also as a potential destabilizing precedent in the domestic domain⁵⁹ Consequently, the Tang launched a series of invasions starting in 644 to restore order within the tributary system. This pattern of intervention extended beyond the Tang era. Both the Ming and Qing dynasties similarly acted in Vietnam to reinstate overthrown monarchs loyal to China.⁶⁰ These military actions underscored the hegemon's role as the guardian of Confucian norms, which emphasize virtue, loyalty, and hierarchical order.

China's approach to military intervention reveals the centrality of legitimacy in shaping its behavior as a hegemon. Generally, the hegemon's self-restraint and avoidance of

⁵⁹ Ju Liu and Weidong Jiang, *History of the Tang's Campaign against Goguryeo* [Tang Zheng Gaogouli Shi] (Jilin: Jilin People's Press, 2006), 49-50.

⁶⁰ Kang et al., "War, Rebellion, and Intervention under Hierarchy," 896-922.

territorial expansion preserved its image as a benevolent leader among subordinate states and thus reinforced the emperor's moral legitimacy in the domestic sphere. However, in cases where the legitimacy of the hierarchical order was directly challenged—whether through defiance or usurpation, China employed military force to uphold its leadership. These interventions were not mere demonstrations of power, but carefully calibrated responses aimed at maintaining the moral and political foundations of the hierarchical system.

The Middle Powers' Pursuit of Legitimacy

The pursuit of domestic legitimacy not only explains the hegemon's self-restraint but also sheds light on the behavior of middle powers within the hierarchy. Fundamentally, middle powers face greater survival challenges, leading their domestic audiences to place a stronger emphasis on the leader's ability to guide the state through intense competition. The competence of middle-power leaders can be credibly demonstrated by securing recognition from the hegemon and achieving military success in external conflicts against other middle powers. In this subsection, we examine Yamato-era Japan and the Three Kingdoms of Korea as case studies to illustrate these dynamics.

From the 5th century onward, the leaders of Yamato Japan actively sought recognition from the Chinese hegemon to strengthen their domestic legitimacy. Starting in 421 CE, five successive Yamato monarchs sent diplomatic envoys to the Southern Dynasties of China whenever a new king ascended the throne. Their goal was to secure formal acknowledgment of their king title and to attain international status equal to, or even superior to, that of other middle powers.⁶¹ Recognition from the Chinese emperor served as a clear signal that the new monarch had secured the support of the most powerful state in their competition with other middle powers. This encouraged domestic audiences in the middle power to trust the China-endorsed monarch's ability to ensure the state's survival, rather than looking to an alternative candidate whose potential performance was uncertain.

The domestic legitimacy of the Yamato monarchs was, like that of the Chinese emperors, particularly fragile during transitions of power, as some of these successions were marked by unrest.⁶² Therefore, when King Zhen of Yamato Japan was awarded the title of General (*jiangjun*) from China, he concurrently sought and

⁶¹ For example, King Zhen sent a diplomatic envoy to China in 438 CE to obtain the title of Great General (*da jiangjun*), a distinction already held by the king of Baekje. This title would grant Yamato Japan the same status as Baekje. Chunren Henei, 74–75.

⁶² Ibid., 91–92.

received lower-ranked titles for 13 aristocrats. These titles varied in rank, which served to differentiate the king from the aristocracy, thereby reinforcing his authority over them. Given that Yamato Japan was largely decentralized during this period, the endorsement from the hegemon was indispensable for the king to build a domestic hierarchy through which he could govern a loosely unified realm.⁶³

Similar patterns appear in the Korean middle powers of the Three Kingdoms period, where rulers sought Chinese recognition as a vital means to reinforce domestic authority, especially during times of political vulnerability.⁶⁴ In Silla, Queen Jindeok ascended the throne as a female monarch—a rarity in her polity—and promptly secured Chinese titles to bolster her position. She also requested permission to adopt Chinese styles of official attire, signaling not just Silla's place within the regional hierarchy but also her personal legitimacy as sovereign. For rulers like Jindeok, imperial titles and symbols operated as crucial signals to domestic elites, confirming that their rule carried the endorsement of the dominant cultural and political power in East Asia. Comparable dynamics appear under rulers such as King Munmu of Silla, who invoked the Chinese emperor's promises of territorial gains after the defeat of

⁶³ Ibid., 79–81.

⁶⁴ Kang, "Authority and Legitimacy in International Relations," 55–71; Lee, "Hegemonic Authority and Domestic Legitimation," 320–52.

Goguryeo to mobilize internal support, demonstrating how external validation by the hegemon could directly bolster domestic unity and resolve. In Baekje, King Mu leveraged Chinese authority to mediate disputes with Silla, enhancing his stature at home by aligning himself with the regional hegemon's influence.⁶⁵

The quest for recognition from the hegemon was not unique to middle powers in Northeast Asia. In its petition to establish tributary relations with the Liu Song Dynasty, the Heluotuo state, located in Southeast Asia, pleaded: "If you show mercy and sympathy, we hope you will send envoys back in due course, so that these neighboring countries will no longer treat us with contempt. This will also spread Your Majesty's reputation far and wide, as one who aids the distressed and supports the weak, which is most needed at present."⁶⁶ In sum, the primary concern for leaders of middle powers is the survival and authority of their states in competition with their peers, and securing external validation from China was conducive to achieving these goals.

⁶⁵ Jonathan W. Best, *A History of the Early Korean Kingdom of Paekche: Together with an Annotated Translation of the Paekche Annals of the Samguk Sagi*, (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2006), 256.

⁶⁶ *Book of Song*, Volume 97.

Military Conquests and Domestic Prestige

Another credible signal that directly reflects a leader's competence—and thereby strengthens their performance legitimacy—is success in external conquests. Indeed, military achievements serve as a tangible demonstration of a leader's capability.

However, in a hierarchical system, a middle power cannot realistically challenge the hegemon due to the evident power disparity. As a result, other peer middle powers naturally become the primary targets for military conquests.

Starting from the early 5th century, Yamato Japan embarked on efforts to extend its influence into the Korean Peninsula. The Gwanggaeto Stele, erected in 414 CE to commemorate the exploits of a Goguryeo king, records Japan's military alliances with Baekje to invade Silla in 391 and 399, as well as its attack on Goguryeo in 404.

Subsequently, Yamato Japan strived to expand into the southern part of the Korean Peninsula to secure the strategically vital resource of iron, and it maintained a certain degree of influence over Silla and Gaya, a tribal confederacy located to the west of Silla.⁶⁷

⁶⁷ Rhee et al., "Korean Contributions to Agriculture, Technology, and State Formation in Japan," 404–59.

It is important to note that while geopolitical and materialistic considerations motivated Yamato Japan's expansion into the Korean Peninsula, these factors alone are insufficient to explain the timing of specific external conquests. Geopolitical and materialistic concerns, such as Yamato Japan's persistent desire for the iron produced in southern Korea, were constant variables—they had always existed. And a constant variable cannot account for variations, such as the frequency of warfare. According to the *Chronicles of Japan (Nihon Shoki)*, the primary motivation for Japan's invasion of Silla in the year 465 was rooted in concerns over domestic authority and political legitimacy. Emperor Yuryaku decided to attack Silla because it had failed to send a tributary envoy since his coming to power eight years earlier, breaking a tradition that had persisted for generations before his reign. Yuryaku explicitly noted that such defiant behavior had not occurred before he came to power, implying that he felt compelled to respond with military action to protect his authority and reputation.⁶⁸ This dynamic highlights how projecting power externally was strategically used to reinforce authority internally.

Drawing on accounts from the *History of the Three Kingdoms*, Korea's premier

⁶⁸ *Chronicles of Japan*, Volume 14.

historical chronicle, we see that rulers in the Three Kingdoms period likewise found that external warfare offered not only strategic gains but also a powerful stage for performing sovereign authority. Military campaigns frequently followed periods of internal discord, suggesting that for many monarchs, demonstrating martial success was essential to stabilizing their rule and projecting competence.

Take, for instance, Goguryeo's King Michon. He ascended the throne after the violent deposition of a predecessor whose tyranny had fractured the royal court. Despite inheriting a kingdom rife with suspicion and lingering factional rivalries, and despite Lelang posing no immediate threat to Goguryeo, Michon launched offensives against Lelang, capturing thousands of people and a large amount of territory.⁶⁹ The decision to engage in such an ambitious campaign so soon after consolidating his rule suggests that external expansion served not merely strategic aims but was also a form of political signaling. By striking outward, Michon transformed a fragile claim to kingship into a vivid display of vigor and capability, reinforcing his legitimacy and demonstrating to domestic elites and rival factions that he was firmly in command.⁷⁰

⁶⁹ *History of the Three Kingdoms*, Volume 17.

⁷⁰ Best, *A History of the Early Korean Kingdom of Paekche*.

In sum, the hierarchical order of early East Asia was shaped by the strategic pursuit of legitimacy across all types of actors. While China maintained its moral authority through restraint, middle powers such as Yamato Japan, Silla, and Goguryeo sought to strengthen their domestic positions by demonstrating deference to the hegemon with displays of military strength. Through diplomatic efforts to gain imperial recognition or military actions against regional rivals, these states used external engagements to signal their rulers' competence and legitimacy to rule. Together, these intertwined dynamics reveal how legitimacy concerns lay at the heart of decisions about war and peace for middle powers within the hierarchical system.

Discussion

Geopolitical Competition as an Alternative Explanation?

Our theory is rooted in the concept of legitimacy, attributing a state's behavior to its strategic pursuit of both international and domestic legitimacy, with the former serving as a credible signal for the latter. A possible alternative explanation is that the strategies adopted by states within a hierarchy—including China and the middle

powers—are driven primarily by the pursuit of material interests, the desire for spheres of influence, the opportunity to attack weak neighbors, and, simply put, concerns over geopolitical competition, rather than considerations of legitimacy.⁷¹ Scholars have long observed that geopolitical strategies such as establishing spheres of influence or securing buffer zones serve both material and symbolic aims, including the pursuit of status and domestic legitimacy.⁷² Therefore, these realist logics do not need to be seen as an alternative explanation to our theory but are, in fact, incorporated into our theoretical framework. Specifically, we posit that geopolitical competition serves as a mediating variable for middle powers, linking the pursuit of domestic legitimacy to the initiation of war.

At its core, a leader's political survival is reasonably their ultimate concern and shapes their strategic choices.⁷³ Consequently, the pursuit of domestic legitimacy serves as the “treatment variable” in our causal framework, driving the adoption of

⁷¹ John J. Mearsheimer, *The Tragedy of Great Power Politics*, Updated ed. (New York: W.W. Norton, 2014).

⁷² Jack L. Snyder, *Myths of Empire: Domestic Politics and International Ambition* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1991); William C. Wohlforth et al., “Moral Authority and Status in International Relations: Good States and the Social Dimension of Status Seeking,” *Review of International Studies* 44, no. 3 (July 2018): 526–46, doi:10.1017/S0260210517000560.

⁷³ Bruce Bueno de Mesquita et al., *The Logic of Political Survival* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2003).

strategies aimed at enhancing the leader's domestic legitimacy. Since leaders of hegemons and middle powers assign different weights to moral and performance legitimacy, the strategies they employ to credibly signal their quality also differ. For leaders of hegemons, demonstrating internationally recognized moral quality to domestic audiences is the primary concern. As a result, the strategies they adopt are generally more pacifist, deviating further from the predictions of realist logic.

On the other hand, the strategies adopted by middle powers toward their peers—such as military conquests, balancing, creating spheres of influence, and securing geopolitical buffers—appear to be driven by geopolitical concerns. For example, when the Yamato kings sought recognition from Chinese emperors as the kings of Japan, they also pursued military authority (*dudu*) over territories including Silla, Baekje, and other entities in southern Korea.⁷⁴ However, the creation of a sphere of influence, the establishment of buffers, and other realist strategies were merely means to a more fundamental goal: credibly demonstrating the leader's ability to defend the state's security and ensure its survival in the face of fierce competition. In this sense, the concern for performance legitimacy drove middle powers to adopt realist strategies targeting other middle powers, including military conquests, which, as

⁷⁴ *Book of Song*, Volume 97.

discussed earlier, enhance performance legitimacy. Therefore, geopolitical concerns are not an alternative explanation to our legitimacy-based theory but rather an integral part of it, functioning as a mediating variable.

Legitimacy or Power?

We will now address two concerns regarding the explanatory power of our legitimacy-based theory. First, if the pursuit of legitimacy is a constant priority, how can it account for the variation in the frequency of wars over time, as shown in Figure 1? In other words, how can a seemingly constant factor explain a variable that fluctuates? While leaders are consistently motivated to adopt strategies that enhance their domestic legitimacy, the intensity of the need for legitimacy can vary. For example, in the case of Chinese hegemons, systematic evidence suggests that the legitimacy of new emperors—particularly those who came to power through irregular means—was often fragile. Consequently, such leaders had a strong incentive to bolster legitimacy by seeking recognition from tributary states.⁷⁵ Similarly, new leaders in middle powers also faced heightened demands for legitimacy, both international and domestic. This dynamic is evident in the case of Yamato Japan,

⁷⁵ Strange, “Legitimacy and Hegemony in Late Imperial China,” 515–48.

where new kings consistently sent tributary envoys to secure recognition from Chinese emperors.

In addition to seeking recognition from the hegemon, leaders of middle powers can directly enhance their domestic legitimacy—specifically, performance legitimacy—through military achievements. This suggests that new leaders of middle powers, upon ascending to power, not only sent tributary envoys to China but also launched invasions against other middle powers. From the data in Tables A1 and A2 in the appendix we can see whether the kings of Goguryeo and Baekje sent tributary envoys to China and conducted invasions against neighboring middle powers during the first five years of their reigns. We focus on the kings of these two states because their recorded reign years are more reliably documented compared to those of Japan and Silla. The data indicate that most Goguryeo and Baekje kings sent tributary envoys to China shortly after coming to power. Moreover, approximately half of the kings in these two states launched invasions against their peers during the first five years of their rule. Hence, the variation in the need for legitimacy correlates with fluctuations in the frequency of war.

The second concern regarding the explanatory power of our framework is whether the

behavior of middle powers was ultimately driven by realpolitik. While we cannot directly control for the potential confounding factor of material power or systematically isolate realist concerns in the analysis of Tables A1 and A2 based on descriptive statistics, little evidence from the cases discussed in the subsection entitled “The Middle Powers’ Pursuit of Legitimacy” suggests a drastic shift in the relative power between the aggressor and the target. For example, when Japan’s Emperor Yuryaku and Goguryeo’s King Michon launched attacks to bolster their domestic legitimacy shortly after assuming power, the balance of power remained largely unchanged within such a short period.

A natural extension of our argument, which distinguishes our framework from a rationalist explanation, is that middle powers tend to exercise more restraint after gaining recognition from the hegemon. Once their status is secured, costly expansion often ceases, even when neighboring states are weak. This is because recognition from the hegemon and territorial expansion into peer states both enhance domestic legitimacy, functioning as substitutes for one another. In the case of Yamato Japan, which sent tributaries to China 13 times during the 5th century, we observe a negative correlation between the number of tributary missions to China and the number of external conquests per decade. Specifically, the Pearson correlation coefficient is -

0.476 (see Table A3 in the appendix). In other words, securing external recognition reduces the need for military achievements to bolster domestic legitimacy.

Imperial Management (Divide-and-Rule) as an Alternative Explanation?

One potential alternative explanation for the hegemon's restraint interprets its inaction as an imperial management strategy. In this view, the hegemon allows or even encourages middle power conflicts as a means to divide and rule. If this interpretation is correct, we would expect the hegemon to refrain from intervening in any middle power conflicts unless one of the middle powers was on the verge of becoming a threat to the hegemon on account of these wars. However, this is evidently not the case. At times, the hegemon was compelled to intervene directly in middle power conflicts when its legitimacy was at stake. For instance, Tang China supported Silla in the mid-7th century during its war against Goguryeo. This intervention was not primarily driven by materialistic concerns and cannot be seen as a preventive war against a middle power that was projected to become a significant threat to the hegemon. After all, this was not the first time Goguryeo nearly unified the Korean Peninsula; its decisive victory over Baekje in 475 brought it even closer to achieving unification, yet this did not provoke any response from China.

The fact that the hegemon intervened in some middle power conflicts but not in others suggests that this variation cannot be explained by a constant concern, such as the divide-and-rule strategy.

Conclusion

In this article, we introduce a legitimacy-based theory to explain the puzzling coexistence of hegemonic peace and middle-power conflict in hierarchical international systems. Our central argument is that leaders' strategic pursuit of domestic legitimacy takes fundamentally different forms depending on their position within the hierarchy. Hegemonic leaders prioritize moral legitimacy, seeking recognition as virtuous exemplars who uphold the normative foundations of the international order. Middle-power leaders, on the other hand, emphasize performance legitimacy, demonstrating competence through recognition from the hegemon and military achievements. These divergent imperatives produce a dualistic regional order characterized by vertical peace and horizontal conflict.

Our legitimacy-based framework makes three interrelated contributions to the study

of middle power diplomacy and hierarchical international order. First, it identifies performance-based domestic legitimacy as a unifying mechanism for understanding diverse middle-power behaviors—including multilateral coalition-building, symbolic competition, and regional military engagement. Second, it attributes behavioral variation among middle powers not merely to functional adaptation, but to strategic responses driven by domestic legitimacy pressures. This helps clarify why middle powers often adopt conciliatory strategies toward hegemons while pursuing aggressive postures toward peer competitors. Third, our findings contribute to the broader theorization of hierarchy by lending support to recent arguments on internal differentiation within hierarchical orders.⁷⁶ Specifically, they show how legitimacy-seeking leaders in middle powers can uphold systemic stratification while simultaneously competing for functional distinction. While middle powers accept their subordinate position in the stratified order, they actively pursue distinctive functional roles—from military prowess to diplomatic leadership—that enhance their value within the hierarchy.

Beyond its explanatory value for conflict behavior in early East Asia, our framework

⁷⁶ Sarah Teo, *Middle Powers in Asia Pacific Multilateralism: A Differential Framework*, (Bristol: Bristol University Press, 2023), doi:10.46692/9781529216493.

offers broader conceptual implications for understanding regional order and stability. Specifically, it helps reconcile two seemingly contradictory dynamics observed in hierarchical systems: openness at the hegemonic level and fragmentation at the middle-power level. Manjeet Pardesi argues that “open” regional orders, characterized by overlapping systems and minimal exclusivity, tend to foster greater stability.⁷⁷ Our analysis complements this insight while introducing a key refinement. Hierarchical orders shaped by legitimacy concerns tend to exhibit openness by the hegemon, as hegemons pursue moral legitimacy through flexibility and broad-based recognition. In contrast, these systems remain fragmented and competitive at the level of the middle powers, where exclusionary behavior is driven by performance-based legitimacy pressures and status anxiety.⁷⁸ This dual dynamic—openness at the top and exclusion below—captures the structure of early East Asia, where the Chinese court maintained tributary inclusivity while Korean kingdoms and Yamato Japan fiercely competed for regional dominance. Our theory thus not only explains observed conflict patterns but also advances understanding of how legitimacy concerns create both openness and

⁷⁷ Manjeet S. Pardesi, “Decentering Hegemony and ‘Open’ Orders: Fifteenth-Century Melaka in a World of Orders,” *Global Studies Quarterly* 2, no. 4 (October 1, 2022): 1–13, doi:10.1093/isagsq/ksac072.

⁷⁸ John de Bhal, “Rethinking ‘Middle Powers’ as a Category of Practice: Stratification, Ambiguity, and Power,” *International Theory* 15, no. 3 (November 2023): 404–27, doi:10.1017/S1752971923000118.

exclusion in hierarchical systems.

Our findings raise a provocative question about the unintended consequences of hegemonic restraint: does the pursuit of moral legitimacy through strategic restraint inadvertently create permissive conditions for conflict among subordinates? While hegemonic restraint and middle-power conflicts may appear as independent phenomena driven by different legitimacy imperatives, they may be causally linked.

The hegemon's avoidance of annexation, necessary to preserve states that can provide voluntary recognition, may unintentionally generate security vacuums that intensify lateral competition. Future comparative research could explore whether similar dynamics operate in other hierarchical systems.

When comparing historical and contemporary hierarchies, we should be cautious about overgeneralization: the incentives for restraint during the tributary era may not necessarily apply directly to modern hegemons. While leaders of both the Chinese empire in the tributary system and the United States today have incentives to build their moral legitimacy, their conceptions of moral pursuits differ. As some international relations theorists have pointed out, Chinese emperors viewed stability and harmony as the manifestation of their moral superiority, whereas contemporary

U.S. leaders consider the spread of democracy and the protection of human rights to be moral responsibilities.⁷⁹ Consequently, historical China largely refrained from intervention and expansion, while the United States frequently adopts interventionist policies.

⁷⁹ David C. Kang, *China Rising: Peace, Power, and Order in East Asia* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2007); G. John Ikenberry, *Liberal Leviathan: The Origins, Crisis, and Transformation of the American World Order*, Princeton Studies in International History and Politics (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2011).